

### **Polarity Analysis Assignment and Grading Rubric**

You are to examine one polarity in any organization or part of an organization that you have worked in, past or present, that was not being managed well. Normally, this would mean that the organization's response to the polarity was out of balance, with too much focus on one side and neglect of the other. A polarity is an interdependent pair (neither can exist without the other) that appears to make opposing demands on an organization. There are two parts to the assignment.

#### **Part 1: Organizational Analysis**

The first is to analyze how this polarity was operating in an organization you were or are a member of at a particular point in time. How was the polarity mismanaged? What were the effects of the way the organization managed that polarity? What kinds of trade-offs did the organization make, and what were the results? Create a Diagram like the following that summarizes your analysis. It's expected that some of the boxes will contain little or no content.

| Left Pole                                | Right Pole                               |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Gifts from focusing on this pole         | Gifts from focusing on this pole         |
| Problems from over-focusing on this pole | Problems from overfocusing on this pole  |
| Problems from underfocusing on this pole | Problems from underfocusing on this pole |

#### **Part 2: How to Better Manage this Polarity**

The second part is to propose how the organization might have managed this polarity more effectively. To do this, identify the higher purpose and deeper fear that would have helped leaders think deeply about the polarity, what practical action steps could have been taken to better manage the polarity, and what early warning measures the organization could have used to notice when the polarity was going out of balance.

See [https://universityinnovation.org/wiki/Resource:Polarity\\_Mapping](https://universityinnovation.org/wiki/Resource:Polarity_Mapping) for further definitions of the elements of a polarity analysis.

**You must choose one of the following polarities to explore. If you want to do a different polarity, discuss with Gervase first**

- Data-driven decisions – people-driven decisions
- Margin-mission
- Short-term – long-term
- Employee interests – organization's interests
- Swift decision-making – informed decision-making
- Anticipate customer needs – respond to customer feedback
- Equip employees – manage costs
- Diversity – equality
- Compete – cooperate

## You will be assessed on:

Part 1: How thoughtful your analysis of the organization's management of the polarity and the depth of your understanding of how each pole shows up in practice and how they need each other. You must provide examples and other data to support your conclusions about how the organization mismanaged the polarity and the results that were created. Avoid vague assertions that things were good or bad – provide evidence to support your assertions. The more discrete your observations and conclusions, the better.

Part 2: The quality and practicality of your proposals for better managing the polarity.

## Grading Rubric

| Part 1 Organizational Analysis                      |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 20                                                  | <b>Clarity of Analysis:</b> How clearly have you described the impact of the organization's approach to this polarity, providing concrete examples to illustrate          |
| 15                                                  | <b>Trade-offs:</b> The extent to which you demonstrate insight into the challenges this polarity created                                                                  |
| 15                                                  | <b>Interdependencies:</b> The extent to which you demonstrate how each pole needed the other for organizational effectiveness                                             |
| 50                                                  | <b>Total Points</b>                                                                                                                                                       |
| Part 2: Proposals for Better Managing this Polarity |                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 5                                                   | <b>North Pole Greater Purpose Statement:</b> What is the best thing that could happen if this polarity were well managed? Do not make it simply they will get both poles. |
| 5                                                   | <b>South Pole Deeper Fear:</b> What happens if there is a lack of balance? Do not make this simply the opposite of the north pole.                                        |
| 10                                                  | <b>Action steps for gaining positive value from the left pole:</b> Practical, doable things the organization can do to get value from a focus on this pole.               |
| 10                                                  | <b>Early Warnings Left Pole:</b> Measurable indicators that will notify the organization that it is entering the downside of the left pole.                               |
| 10                                                  | <b>Action steps for gaining positive value from the right pole:</b> Practical, doable things the organization can do to get value from a focus on this pole.              |
| 10                                                  | <b>Early Warnings Right Pole:</b> Measurable indicators that will notify the organization that it is entering the downside of the right pole.                             |
| 50                                                  | <b>Total Points</b>                                                                                                                                                       |

Maximum of 2,000 words, not including diagram(s). Do not expect diagrams to be self-explanatory; they can foreshadow or summarize what you write.

This assignment is worth 20% of your overall course grade.